

a professional layout, with the menu laid out on one screen, so you don't need to hunt around for the various options. The home page of the software provides all accounting data at a glance, and this can be configured. The data entry forms are also very user-friendly, making data entry quite easy. The browser interface of the software means that you have buttons for back, forward, home, etc, which make navigation through different forms a snap.

The software saves data in tiny file sizes, so you can back up and entire year's accounts on a floppy! eBiz Technologies, the developers, claim that 5,000 entries of data can be backed up in a file no larger than 200 KB. The software also has an option to import data from Tally, so switching over to T++ should not be a problem at all. The import is done using XML, so you can import everything from masters to transaction records.

The Advanced Search function in the Search option helps you perform complex searches, and also allows you to save search criteria for future use. There are two options to define inventory, 'groups' and 'category'-most software offer only one of these options. These groups and categories can be divided into various levels, which will let you have

The reports page of the software shows you the entire set of reports at a glance, and you can go down to the voucher level in each report. Reports can be exported in various formats, including e-mail. Reports can also be customised and exported to MS Excel as a template.

Tally 6.3
www.tallysolutions.com

Tally has an intuitive interface, and has features that will take care of just about any accounting requirement. Though the feature set isn't really very different from other software, it's the easy menu layout and accessibility of functions that earns Tally top marks in terms of ease of use.

A major irritant with Tally 6.3 is the product activation process.

Tally Solutions Pvt. Ltd., 1999-2004	
Tally ERP 9.00 - Release 3.14	
Year: 1999, From: 2003	
Ratio Analysis	
Sheet 1	
Principal Groups	Sheet 2
	For: 1-Apr-2003
	Principal Ratios
Assets Group	Current Ratio
Current Assets - Current Liabilities	Current Assets / Current Liabilities
Bank Accounts	Quick Ratio
Bank Accounts	Current Assets - Stock in Hand / Current Liabilities
Working Capital	Gross Profit %
Working Capital	(Gross Profit % / Sales) * 100
Net Profit	Net Profit %
Net Profit	(Net Profit / Sales) * 100
Operating Cost	Operating Cost %
Operating Cost	(Operating Cost / Sales) * 100
Return on Capital	Return on Capital
Return on Capital	(Return on Capital / Capital Employed) * 100
Return on Investment	Return on Investment
Return on Investment	(Return on Investment / Investment) * 100
Return on Equity	Return on Equity
Return on Equity	(Return on Equity / Equity) * 100

As with other software vendors such as Microsoft and Symantec, Tally too, demands activation of the product before you can use it. Sounds simple enough, right? Wrong! Most small businesses have standalone computers for accounting, and they don't risk connecting this computer to the Internet, or just don't have an Internet connection—which is why the inbuilt browser isn't really a great feature!

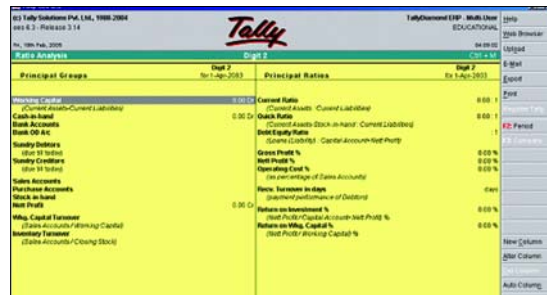
Tally also sports additional features: it lets you easily export data to ODBC software such as MS Word or Excel; it offers a print preview of accounting reports; it allows you to export your data in the XML format—this goes a long way in allowing those without Tally installed to view or use the data. Tally also allows for unified ledgers, ratio analysis, and more.

Overall, those with earlier versions of Tally might not want to upgrade, for three reasons: the irritating activation feature, the price, and of course, the faster speeds that the earlier DOS-based versions of Tally, such as Tally 4.5, offer.

Both our experts were unanimous about Tally 6.3's easy-to-use interface. Also, they were both quick to point out that the surplus of Tally-trained professionals who are looking for jobs would reduce the total cost of ownership of the package, as no additional training would be required.

Wings EZ was our winner last year. Compared to the other software we tested, Wings offers more or less the same features. It is easy to use, and has a very simple interface. All the reports generated have a very similar look, and can be comprehended easily. Extra columns can be added to the report to display any extra information required.

Wings EZ has an option that allows you to keep track of PDCs and bounced cheques. It allows



Tally is to accounting what Microsoft is to operating systems